CPI(M), who have so far been loyal to the BRS in the state, may also drift to the Congress side if the perception about the tacit BJP ties firms up.

A majority in the 119-seat assembly is still a far cry, though. The Congress's strength now largely lies in the Khammam, Nalgonda and Mahbubnagar regions and parts of Warangal and Nizamabad. To aim higher, it will need to break into BRS strongholds in north Telangana, including Hyderabad and the skirting Ranga Reddy districts, which account for 24 seats. State unit chief A. Revanth Reddy talks confidently about winning 80 seats. Like in Karnataka, party sources say the poll manifesto will be simple and direct, with five key guarantees to cover most of the electorate. Congress contestants, at least for half the seats, may be named well in advance so as to ease constituency-wise micromanagement. Poll strategist Sunil Kanugolu's assessments are likely to be a key factor in choosing contestants.

In 2018, a complacent Congress had hoped to ride piggy-back on anti-incumbency. Not only did that not happen, the party also lost 12 of its 19 MLAs to KCR post-poll. To avoid such mishaps, the party is being extra cautious about its candidates: two MPs have already been roped in for the contest. Will all this suffice? "KCR's family rule, joblessness, inflation and the BJP's internal feuds hold positives for the Congress," says Prof. E. Venkatesu of the University of Hyderabad. "But factionalism and dominant caste hegemony continue to be problems." A real revival would address all lacunae. ■



**ON OPPOSITE POLES** Tamil Nadu governor R.N. Ravi with CM Stalin at a Gandhi Jayanti programme

ANI

TAMIL NADU

# A STILLBORN MOVE

By Amarnath K. Menon

First came the step into the grey zone, then the hurried backtracking. On June 29 evening, Tamil Nadu governor R.N. Ravi dismissed the corruption-tainted V. Senthil Balaji—presently under judicial custody—from the state council of ministers. But, late that night, Raj Bhavan told the chief minister's office that the dismissal order was to be kept in abeyance. Ravi is believed to have communicated that the Union home ministry advised him to first take the attorney general's advice. Ravi has been taking on the M.K. Stalin-led DMK government ever since he became governor in September 2021 (*see graphic*). This time, clearly, the BJP-ruled Centre chose to err on the side of caution and avoid embarrassment on a constitutional matter that has not stood the test of legality.

Ravi's action did focus attention on a question beyond that of its own legality: the phenomenon of ministers continuing in their posts even without portfolios. After his arrest, Balaji had been merely divested of his electricity portfolio, via a press note issued by the state government on June 16, while being retained in the ministry. But Ravi's somewhat unprecedented intervention has been politically advantageous to the DMK. In ignoring the SC's interpretation that the power of a governor flows from the "aid and advice" of the council of ministers, Ravi has given the DMK government enough political ammunition in a case that was otherwise beginning to be a burden for Stalin. Now, many think Ravi's action has eased the pressure exerted by the AIADMK and BJP on the DMK vis-à-vis corruption.

The events in Maharashtra—where several MLAs facing corruption probes by central agencies joined the BJP-Sena government—too have reverberated in Tamil Nadu, especially with breakaway NCP leader Ajit Pawar taking the high-profile post of deputy chief minister. "The induction of Ajit Pawar, already facing an ED case in a Maharashtra court, has made the Balaji case look more a political than a legal one," says political commentator N. Sathiya Moorthy. But realpolitik aside, a constitutional dilemma has woven itself into an already knotty affair through the governor's hasty action.

Balaji was arrested on June 14 by the Enforcement Directorate (ED) in a money-laundering case related to the nine-year-old cash-for-jobs scam. Developing chest pain after hours of grilling, he was hospitalised and finally underwent heart surgery on June 21, and has been in judicial custody since. The